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PSYC100

Anchoring & framing effects

Today
Welcome to your next lesson: Anchoring & framing effects.

I'm getting your personalized lesson ready — based on what you've learned, what's next, and the best way for you to build on your progress.

Step by step, you're moving forward.

Let’s start with a quick thought experiment, Ron 🔍

Imagine I ask you:

“Is the Mississippi River longer or shorter than 5,000 miles?

Now, what’s your best guess of its actual length?”

Don’t look it up. Just go with your gut.

Reply with two things:

Longer or shorter than 5,000 miles?
Your actual length estimate (a single number in miles).

Then we’ll use your answer to uncover our first bias: anchoring.

shorter

Nice, thanks Ron 👍

One more thing: give me your best guess for the actual length of the Mississippi in miles — just a single number.

Then I’ll show you how that 5,000 number I gave you quietly pulled on your estimate (that’s the anchoring effect).

1500 miles

Great, thank you 👀

Here’s what just happened, step by step:

I slipped in a big number: 5,000 miles
You then guessed: 1,500 miles

That first number (5,000) acts like a mental “anchor”.

Even if you know it’s too big, your later estimate is pulled toward it without you noticing.

Anchoring effect = the first number or piece of information we see quietly drags our later judgments toward it.

You don’t need the real length yet — what matters is the pull from that first number.

Does this idea of “the first number pulling your estimate” make sense so far, or should I walk through one more everyday example (like shopping or salary)?

Makes sense to me

What do you think the anchor is here? 👇

In this situation, what exactly is the anchor?

A.

The actual (real-world) length of the Mississippi River

B.

The first number you were shown: 5,000 miles

C.

Your final guess: 1,500 miles

D.

The fact that it’s a famous U.S. river

Nice job, Ron — you nailed it 🎯

The anchor is: the first number you were shown: 5,000 miles.

That number matters because:

It comes before your estimate
Your brain uses it as a starting point, then adjusts (but usually not enough)
So even if you know it’s too big, your guess is still pulled toward it
Next step: let’s look at a simple everyday anchoring example (like online shopping) so you can spot it in the real world.

Which sounds more interesting to you:

A price example (shopping / sales)
A salary example (job negotiation)

price

Perfect, let’s use a price example 💸

Imagine this:

You see a jacket online:

Original price shown first: $260 (crossed out)
“SALE TODAY: $149”

Many people think, “Wow, that’s a good deal,” even if $149 is more than they planned to spend.

Step by step:

The $260 acts as the anchor (starting point)
Your brain compares $149 to $260 and thinks: “That’s much lower”
You feel it’s cheap compared to the anchor, not in absolute terms

So:

The anchor here is the first price you see (the “original” price), which makes the sale price feel more attractive.

Quick check:

In that jacket example, what is doing the “pulling” on your sense of what’s expensive or cheap — the sale price or the original price? Just answer in a few words.

ther origjinal pricer, the anchor

Exactly right ☑

The original price is the anchor — it sets the starting point for your sense of “expensive” or “cheap,” and the sale price feels better relative to that anchor, not on its own.

Now I want to show you the cousin of anchoring: framing — where wording (not numbers) changes how we feel about the same outcome.

Ready to see a quick framing example next?

Yes, I'm ready

Nice 🔚 let’s switch to framing.

Same facts, different wording:

Doctor A says: “This surgery has a 90% survival rate.”
Doctor B says: “This surgery has a 10% death rate.”

Both describe the same numbers, but most people feel much safer with Doctor A’s wording.

Framing effect = when the way information is worded (gain vs loss, survival vs death,

etc.) changes choices, even though the facts are the same.

Quick gut reaction:

Which doctor's wording feels safer to you — A (90% survival) or B (10% death)? Just say A or B.

a

Same for most people — A feels safer, even though A and B say the exact same thing 📊

Here's the key idea:

Anchoring = the first number pulls your judgment
Framing = the wording (like survival vs death) changes how you feel about the same facts

So now you've seen:

Numbers can anchor you
Words can frame your decision
Before we practice with a few short scenarios, quick check:

Would you like me to

show a small visual/table comparing anchoring vs framing, or
jump straight into practice questions where you label which bias is happening?
Go to practice questions

What do you think is going on here? Take your time with the question below 👇

In this situation, which bias is most obvious?

A website shows a laptop as:

"WAS $1,399 – NOW ONLY $999!!!"

You didn't plan to buy a laptop, but the discount makes it feel like a rare opportunity and you seriously consider it.

Which bias is doing most of the work here?

A.

Anchoring (the original price makes $999 feel cheaper)

B.

Framing (it's framed as gain vs. loss)

C.

Availability (you remember other sales you've seen)

D.

Representativeness (it matches your idea of a "high-end laptop")

Nice work, Ron — you spotted that perfectly 🎯

This is anchoring because:

The original price $1,399 is the anchor

Your brain compares $999 to that anchor and thinks: “Wow, that’s a big drop”
That relative drop makes you consider buying, even if $999 is still a lot

So the number doing the work is the first one you see, not the actual need for a laptop.

Let’s try another one where it might be anchoring or framing and you have to choose between them 👇

ok

What do you think this one is showing most clearly? Take your time with the question above 👆

A public health message says:

“If people wear masks, we can SAVE 500 lives this month.”

Same underlying numbers, but imagine a second version said:

“If people don’t wear masks, 500 people will DIE this month.”

If both versions are describing the same situation, and the only thing that changes is whether it says SAVE lives vs DIE, which bias is this mainly showing?

A.

Anchoring (a first number pulling estimates)

B.

Framing (different wording for the same outcome)

C.

Availability (remembering similar events)

D.

Representativeness (matching a stereotype of danger)

You’re on a roll, Ron 👌

You were right: this is framing because:

The facts stay the same (500 people either way)
Only the wording changes: “SAVE lives” vs “DIE”
That change in frame (gain vs loss) can change how strongly people react or what they choose

So here, it’s not a first number pulling you — it’s the emotional impact of the wording around the same numbers.

Want to do one more mixed scenario where you decide if it’s anchoring or framing (or both), and you tell me which one is stronger?

Yes, let's try it

Take your time with the question above 👆

A hospital notice says:

Version 1: "The new treatment has a 70% success rate." Version 2: "The new treatment has a 30% failure rate."

Same treatment. Same underlying numbers. But patients react more positively to Version 1.

Which bias is most clearly shown here?

A.

Anchoring – the first number someone hears pulls their estimate

B.

Framing – different wording (success vs failure) for the same outcome

C.

Availability – people recall stories about treatments they've heard of

D.

Representativeness – it matches their stereotype of a "good treatment"

You're really locking this in, Ron 👀

You were right again: this is framing because:

The numbers are identical (70% success = 30% failure)
Only the frame changes: "success" vs "failure"
That wording shift changes how safe/good the treatment feels, even though nothing factual changed

So:

Anchoring = first number pulls you
Framing = different wording of the same facts shifts your preference
To wrap this into your own life:

Can you think of a recent decision (buying something, a news headline, medical info, anything) where you now suspect there was either:

an anchor (a first number), or
a frame (positive vs negative wording)

Describe just one briefly, and tell me whether you think it was anchoring or framing.

when i describe to who think skydivers aer suicidal that there are ovaaverage 30 ftalaties world wide, if i just said that itd sound like a lot , bit by framing it as there are about 5 million jumps world wide a year and only 30 fatalaties it comes acrfoss as safer to people

Ron, that is an excellent real-world example 👏

Let me restate it cleanly, step by step:

If you just say: "There are about 30 fatalities from skydiving each year worldwide," it sounds scary.
But if you say: "There are about 5 million jumps a year and only ~30 fatalities," it suddenly feels much safer.

The facts are the same.

What changes is the frame:

First version: focuses on death count → feels dangerous
Second version: frames it as tiny risk per jump → feels safer

That's classic framing effect ☑

You’re using framing on purpose to correct a distorted fear and give people a more accurate sense of risk.

You’ve:

Correctly identified anchors in number/price examples
Correctly identified frames in wording examples
Created your own clear framing example from your life

You’ve basically mastered the goal for this lesson 🎯

Last check from me:

Do you feel ready to wrap up this anchoring & framing lesson and move to the next one, or do you want a couple more practice questions first?

I'm ready to move on

Love it. You’ve got this lesson down, Ron 🎓

Quick recap in your words:

Anchoring = when a first number (like $1,399 or 5,000 miles) quietly pulls later judgments toward it, even if you know it might be off.
Framing = when the same facts feel different because of how they’re worded (success vs failure, save vs die, “30 fatalities” vs “30 out of 5 million jumps”).
You not only spotted these in examples, you used a great skydiving example to show framing in real life. That’s real understanding, not just memorizing 👏

When you’re ready, go ahead and start the next lesson in your Learn tab, and I’ll keep building on this with you step by step.